

coastline, on the one hand, and the small size of the Union navy, on the other. The new nation in the South had 3,549 miles (5,712km) of coastline, including 180 inlets, and when President Lincoln ordered the blockade to begin just after the fall of Fort Sumter, the Union navy had only 14 ships available.

At the start of the Civil War, while the blockade did little to stop ships engaged in blockade-running—an activity that became a major industry during the war—it did help to isolate the South diplomatically. The British government ultimately declared itself neutral, but it also respected the Union's right to enforce a blockade in wartime. This acknowledgment of the Union navy's right to inspect shipping entering Confederate ports and seize contraband property became significant as the Union navy increased in size, thus becoming more and more able to enforce the blockade. As the world's preeminent naval power, and one that wished to set legal precedents for its own imposition of blockades in future wars as in the past, the British government had good reason to recognize the legality of this Union war measure, and little reason to risk a war with Lincoln's government over this issue.

In order to enforce this blockade, the Union rapidly expanded its navy. By the end of the war, the Department of the Navy under Gideon Welles's leadership had purchased some 418 additional ships and built another 208. Most were in the service of tightening the blockade. The Union navy also increased in numbers from about 1,500 officers and men to 58,000. Although the maritime force very much remained the junior service to the hugely expanded Union army, this still represented an unprecedented increase in U.S. naval power.

While the increase in ships clearly tightened the blockade, only the capture of the South's ports could provide a foolproof way of restricting Confederate shipping. Swift steamers traveling at night often eluded Union patrol ships, and even in 1865, when the siege was at its tightest, about half of all Confederate blockade-runners completed their voyages.

1,149 The number of ships that were captured by the Union navy while attempting to run the North's blockade of the South.